leaders need, how is India's most respected business school preparing for the next era of management education?

Leading this transformation is Professor Bharat Bhasker, Director of IIM Ahmedabad. An information technology leader with nearly three decades of experience across industry, research, teaching and consulting in India and globally, he took charge of the institute in March 2023.

In this conversation with *Business Today*, he discusses how IIM Ahmedabad is preparing students for the future, why judgement will become a defining leadership skill in the AI era, and how Indian business schools can shape global management thinking. Edited excerpts:

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What does it really take to stay at the top year after year, given the competitive dynamics in management education?

Thank you. It is gratifying to know that we are maintaining our course. There will always be challenges, but our focus remains on our main goal: creating leaders for the corporate sector in India. That requires attention to three or four key areas.

The first is investing in faculty and keeping them motivated, because ultimately an institution is nothing but a group of faculty members. The second is that research impact must be significant—the aim is that our research is referenced by industry, rather than papers being published for their own sake. The third is our alumni network. We are also occupied with the question of what management education will look like in the next 10 to 20 years, what transformations are occurring in industry, and the likely impact on management education. We continue to reinvent the MBA before it needs reinventing—this has been one of the fundamental aspects of our approach. We prepare management graduates for 10 years down the line, so in 2026, we are educating them for 2036. That mindset is probably what distinguishes us from many other management schools and makes us a unique institution in the country.

Lastly, there is our international focus. Over the past five decades, our output was oriented toward the Indian marketplace, but our graduates have also performed exceptionally well globally.

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Given the conflict in West Asia, has there been any impact on the goals of your first foray into that region?

Yes, it has had an impact, mainly due to the uncertainty in February and March. We have had to bring our batch back from Dubai to India, and for two months they studied here because we were unsure which way the situation would unfold. In April, they returned to Dubai, and it took us another month or so to settle back in.

Our faculty continue to teach there happily, and students are finding jobs in that market—placements have been quite good. I would not like to give exact numbers, as releasing them is the placement chairperson's prerogative, but I can say the salaries and roles our students are securing are very competitive.

Our foray is still on track. We are launching a two-year weekend MBA programme, because we found that many people in that market are immigrants from various countries who cannot leave their jobs to join a full-time, one-year MBA programme.

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Our survey suggests that overall admissions to business schools, including some IIMs, have been a little muted this year. What factors are at play here?

The factors at play mainly concern the top 30 or 40 management institutes—the ones producing genuine corporate leaders, out of roughly 50 or 60 institutes overall contributing to management education in the country. Among the top 20,